VW defends Audi's American investment

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【要点】

・フォルクスワーゲンはアウディの米国投資が長期的な戦略の一部であり、米国での地域的な足がかりを広げるための取り組みと述べている。

・アウディは米国にSUV生産工場を建設するため40億ユーロを投資する予定で、トランプ大統領就任時の関税によってフォルクスワーゲンは今年約28億ユーロの損失が見込まれている。

・ドイツの極右政党「ドイツのための選択肢」(AfD)はアウディの米国投資をドイツが事業地として魅力的でなくなった証拠として、メルツ首相と前任者を批判している。

・欧州の自動車メーカーは売上の急落と利益低下を報告しており、電気自動車販売のみが好調であるが、業界全体としては厳しい状況が続いている。

【メール原文】

Presented by BMW Group By MARTINA SAPIO with JORDYN DAHL and TOMMASO LECCA SNEAK PEEK — Germany's far-right party is seizing on Audi's potential U.S.

Presented by BMW Group

By MARTINA SAPIO

with JORDYN DAHL and TOMMASO LECCA

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SNEAK PEEK

— Germany's far-right party is seizing on Audi's potential U.S. investment as further proof the country is in decline.

— Wizz Air CEO József Váradi warned that airlines with expiring fuel hedging contracts will have difficulty surviving the winter due to high jet fuel prices.

— Eight EU countries are pushing Brussels for looser state aid rules in regions hit by the fallout from Russia's war.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

Mark your calendars: Our weekly mobility calendar landed in your inbox on Thursday. You can also go online to export and plan your week or suggest your own event.

Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us @tommylecca , @jordyndahl and @martsapio .

DRIVING THE DAY

VOLKSWAGEN DEFENDES AUDI'S US INVESTMENT: While the German automaker wouldn't give specific figures or comment on the state of the negotiations, Volkswagen told media and investors on Thursday that Audi's U.S. investment is part of a longer-term strategy. "This step would be fully consistent with our regional strategy in the U.S ⋯ as part of our global strategy to broaden our regional footprint," Arno Antlitz, VW's chief financial and operational officer, said on an earnings call.

Catch up: Gernot Döllner, CEO of the VW subsidiary, appeared at a campaign rally for President Donald Trump where it was announced that Audi plans to invest €4 billion to build a plant to produce SUVs for the market. German politicians quickly lambasted Döllner's appearance.

All about trade: The move would "reduce our exposure to trade barriers," Antlitz said. The tariffs put in place at the start of President Donald Trump's second term will cost Volkswagen around €2.8 billion this year. The automaker has already paid €1.2 billion so far this year, Antlitz said. It still "requires approval by the relevant committees," he said, declining to give details on what the process entails.

Your fault: The far-right Alternative for Germany seized the news as further proof that the country is no longer a desirable business location, blaming German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and his predecessors. "The wake-up call that the Audi boss has sent from the USA to Germany is deafening," AfD leader Alice Weidel said in a press release .

Not a first: The AfD used the crisis engulfing the automotive sector to win over voters in state elections earlier this year. Most of Europe's automakers held their third-quarter earnings call this week, painting a grim picture with plummeting sales and lower-than-expected profits. The one bright spot is electric vehicle sales, but that only serves to undercut the industry's asks for flexibility on emission targets. More on that here .

AVIATION

WINTER IS COMING FOR UNHEDGED AIRLINES, WIZZ AIR CEO WARNS: Choosing the right jet fuel hedging strategy could become a matter of survival for European airlines, according to Wizz Air CEO József Váradi. In an interview with POLITICO, Váradi praised his airline's decision to adopt a rolling 18-month hedging program that caps fuel prices through October 2027, although it does not cover all of its fuel consumption. Unhedged competitors could go out of business as early as this winter, he warned. "We know how cold winter can become, given the fuel prices," he said. Read more here .

It's a curse! Wizz Air has faced numerous setbacks over the last five years, from the war in Ukraine, which affected its Central and Eastern European home market, to instability in the Middle East, which forced it to scale back its expansion into medium-haul routes in the region. Last but not least is the Pratt & Whitney engine crisis, which grounded 20% of Wizz Air's fleet when the mass recall was announced.

Alive and kicking: Despite these issues, Váradi is convinced his airline is on track to become Europe's "cost leader" thanks to its young, fuel-efficient fleet and extensive network. "I'm no longer a tiny little airline coming from Central-Eastern Europe, supplying the labor for Western European demand," he told Tommaso. That's how the airline started he said, noting that its customer base has evolved to include

more “leisure travelers,” while the Hungarian carrier has also expanded into Italy, Spain and the U.K.

But analysts remain skeptical. “Wizz Air’s fundamental problem is that it has been extremely successful at growing passenger numbers, but much less successful at translating that growth into sustainable profitability,” said Wouter Dewulf, an air transport economist at the University of Antwerp. “The fundamental challenge is not filling aircraft, but filling them at fares that generate sustainable margins,” Dewulf told Tommaso.

Ryanair of the East? Linus Benjamin Bauer, an aviation consultant at BAA & Partners, considers Wizz Air a success story, but one that still faces significant challenges. “Váradi built Wizz from scratch in 2003,” Bauer said, noting that “it has democratized air travel for millions of Romanians, Hungarians and Poles.” But “Wizz will earn the ‘Ryanair of the East’ label only when it proves it can generate returns through the cycle,” he added, noting that the carrier currently lacks “consistent profitability and balance-sheet strength.”

Enlargement airline: During his visit to Brussels Wednesday, Váradi said his airline was “very pro-European,” as it flourished thanks to the liberalization of European aviation, which turned the EU into a single aviation market. But Wizz Air is also “the enlargement airline,” he said, because it is the leading carrier in Western Balkan countries that are candidates for EU membership.

A message from BMW Group: Europe’s automotive transition won’t move at one pace – or work the same way for everyone. What makes electric mobility a practical choice? Explore how charging access, affordability, and everyday mobility needs shape the mobility transition across countries in this immersive data story.

TRANSPORT

EXCLUSIVE — EASTERN EU COUNTRIES SEEK STATE AID FLEX: Eight EU countries are calling for looser state aid rules to help businesses in regions affected by Russia’s war against Ukraine, our colleague Francesca Micheletti reports, a push with clear implications for transport and connectivity along the bloc’s eastern border, where governments face growing security and infrastructure pressures.

GBER review: Bulgaria, Estonia, Hungary, Latvia, Lithuania, Poland, Romania and Slovakia want the Commission to build special provisions for regions bordering Russia, Belarus and Ukraine into its review of the General Block Exemption Regulation, the EU’s main state aid framework.

What they want: The group is asking for higher permitted aid intensities, higher notification thresholds and easier access to support in those regions. It is also seeking block exemptions for the development and acquisition of dual-use goods, technologies and infrastructure — a potentially important opening for transport projects such as rail, roads, logistics hubs and other links that serve both civilian and military needs.

And another route: The GBER review is not the only avenue. The Commission’s upcoming revision of the Regional Aid Guidelines could also offer more scope to reflect the specific circumstances of these regions, although broader exemptions for dual-use activities may prove harder given the Commission’s limited state aid practice in that area.

MARITIME

GREECE TAKES ITS SEA ROW GLOBAL: Greek Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis used a U.N. Security Council debate on maritime security to argue that the disputed Turkey-Libya sea-border deal is not just

a bilateral quarrel, but part of a broader challenge to the rules governing trade, navigation and security at sea.

His case: Mitsotakis called the memorandum “illegal” and “arbitrary,” arguing that Turkey and Libya do not have opposite or adjacent coasts and that the deal effectively ignores Greek islands including Crete, Rhodes, Karpathos and Kasos. He said its recent ratification by Libya’s House of Representatives cannot give it legal force.

Bigger than Greece: “This is not simply a bilateral dispute,” Mitsotakis said, linking the row to the wider question of whether states can pick and choose the rules at sea. He also warned that such claims could be used to obstruct strategic connectivity projects in the Eastern Mediterranean, including infrastructure tied to energy security, electricity and data links.

And beyond the East Med: Mitsotakis widened the argument to the Black Sea, Red Sea and Strait of Hormuz, saying maritime routes can no longer be assumed to be safe. He condemned the latest attack on a Greek-owned commercial vessel in the Black Sea and called for a “global maritime truce” to protect civilian shipping.

Message to Europe: The Greek leader said the EU cannot remain a “spectator” when its trade routes are threatened and called for stronger European operational capabilities and a bigger security presence in the region, pointing to the EU’s ASPIDES mission in the Red Sea as a model.

INDIAN BEACHING YARDS ON ENVI’S MIND: A coalition of MEPS from centrist and leftist parties in the European Parliament’s Environment Committee have put forward an objection to the EU’s listing of two Indian beaching yards under its Ship Recycling Regulation. Our colleagues at Morning Sustainability scooped the document here . The lawmakers claim the new additions do not meet the law’s environmental requirements; read this letter sent earlier to Commissioners Roswall and Séjourné here . The shipping industry, however, insists the yards have undergone an extensive inspection process, arguing that facilities outside Europe should be recognized when meeting the bloc’s standards.

PIT STOPS

Top EU diplomat Kaja Kallas is expected to use the G20 foreign ministers meeting today to push for a Black Sea freedom-of-navigation arrangement, oppose tolls on international shipping routes and warn against Russia’s weaponization of food, while also making the case for more resilient raw-material supply chains.

A message from BMW Group: Europe’s automotive transition is underway, but turning investment and ambition into a successful industrial transformation will require more than targets alone. This immersive data story explores three questions: what it takes to turn investment into competitive battery production; how complementary solutions can deliver real emissions reductions, and what makes the transition practical, affordable and attractive for consumers and businesses. Europe has made significant progress towards net zero. The next challenge is turning that progress into competitive industrial capacity, measurable emissions reductions and mobility solutions that work for households and businesses across the continent. What will it take for Europe’s automotive transition to succeed? Read the immersive data here .

Headlines

Here’s a recap of yesterday’s news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

Everything that went wrong with Spain’s high-speed railways

Spain’s high-speed rail network once embodied the country’s rise as a modern European power. Deadly crashes are raising fresh questions over safety, maintenance and years of investment choices.

By Aitor Hernández-Morales, Martina Sapio · Oct 29, 2026, 10:21 pm Europe/Brussels CET

Rising electric car sales complicate auto industry plea for emissions leniency

The industry maintains flexibility is needed to stop the cutting of jobs and retain competitiveness.

By Jordyn Dahl · Oct 29, 2026, 07:24 pm Europe/Brussels CET

Jet fuel prices will bankrupt airlines this winter, but not Wizz Air, CEO says

The Hungarian budget carrier says its fuel hedging contracts will shield it from the worst of the crisis facing its competitors.

By Tommaso Lecca · Oct 29, 2026, 03:09 pm Europe/Brussels CET

Quebec premier boycotts Mark Carney’s EU summit

In a letter to European leaders, Paul St-Pierre Plamondon warns that agreements running counter to Quebec’s interests “will simply not be implemented.”

By Jacob Parry · Oct 29, 2026, 10:59 am Europe/Brussels CET

Weekly Calendar

Here’s a selection of upcoming key events, find the complete Week Ahead online.

Council Working Party on Space

Nov 3, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Eurocontrol ‘EASA Member States’ Advisory Body Meeting

Nov 3, 2026, 9:00 AM - Nov 4, 2026, 5:00 PM · Cologne, DE

Competitive Germany Summit

Nov 3, 2026, 10:00 AM - 8:00 pm

Coreper II

Nov 4, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Eurocontrol ‘Network Director of Technology’

Nov 4, 2026, 9:00 AM - 4:30 pm · Brussels, BE

Beyond the Glass: Brewing Local Competitiveness

Nov 4, 2026, 5:30 PM - 9:00 pm

European Grouping of Territorial Cooperation Brussels Days

Nov 5, 2026 - Nov 6, 2026 · Brussels, BE

European Pulse Seminar 2026

Nov 5, 2026, 8:00 AM - 5:00 pm

Eurocontrol ‘ATM Transformation Conference’ Event

Nov 5, 2026, 8:00 AM · Brussels, BE

Pro Roundtable – Trade

Nov 5, 2026, 8:15 AM - 9:45 am

EUROCONTROL 'Network Directors of Operations Forum/Directors of Technology/Operations Team' Joint session
Nov 5, 2026, 9:00 AM - 4:00 pm · Brussels, BE

Shaping the Next Phase of the SIU
Nov 5, 2026, 5:00 PM - 8:00 pm

Coreper I
Nov 6, 2026 · Brussels, BE

POLITICO Spotlight – Confederatia Patronala Concordia
Nov 6, 2026, 9:00 AM - 12:00 pm

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